

Standard Error-Codes Reference

Day 3 handout. The "what do I do now?" guarantee. The seven most-needed error responses, what each means, what the body should carry — and a standard error-body shape to use across your whole API.

CODE	MEANING	BODY SHOULD INCLUDE
400	Bad request (validation)	Field-by-field errors with codes
401	Unauthenticated	Hint: SSO challenge or token-refresh path
403	Authenticated but unauthorized	Required scope name
404	Resource doesn't exist	Resource type + identifier
409	Conflict (idempotency / state)	What conflicted; how to resolve
422	Validated but business-rule violation	Which rule; which fields involved
429	Rate-limited	Retry-After header; current limit

Standardize the error-body shape across the API

Every error response should use the same shape, so callers can parse failures uniformly:

```
{
  "error": {
    "code": "ticket_not_eligible",
    "message": "Ticket cannot be reconciled in current state",
    "fields": [{"name": "ticket_ids[3]", "reason": "ticket already reconciled"}]
  },
  "request_id": "req_01H...",
  "documentation_url": "https://docs.../errors/ticket_not_eligible"
}
```

The discipline

- Don't lump failures at `400` / `500`. The specific `409` / `422` / `429` codes carry actionable distinctions a caller can act on.
- A machine-readable `code`, a human `message`, a `request_id` for support, and a `documentation_url` turn "it failed" into "here's what to do next."